

Off the Shelf



Stronghold Crusader

A castle-building sin. Indulge

Religion is in the air and once again you are required to extend your dominion beyond grey castle walls and smite all those on the wrong side of the moat. Like its predecessor, *Crusader* demands diligence, a tactical approach to missions and a level of micromanagement that ought to have been discarded.

You will lead a host of new units against a better AI in the arid deserts of the Middle East—the Holy Crusades demand action and you are to deliver. Deliverance comes in the form of armies that are weaned on resources such as food, leather, ale, bread and weapons. Managing your economy and overseeing your military machine are the dual tasks that you will indulge in; since an army marches on its stomach, a strong economy will see you victorious through most tussles.

Keep your people happy (a tavern always helps), tax wisely and you will have a well-oiled economy feeding a growing army.

The other part of the equation is simple enough: throw your guys against their

guys, and with a little juggling of your medieval units you should be on top when the dust settles. Set in the desert, arable land is hard to come by within the game, throwing yet another challenge to the mix.

Often you will find yourself holding desperately on to a piece of green that is irritatingly close to the borders of your foes. It is a heady mix, nevertheless, one that demands tactics; but winning a close fight is rewarding enough.

The game includes four campaign modes—which let you play as both sides—and a skirmish mode. Isometric views, frame the pretty game design. The music—Arabic and moody—is a perfect companion to both the lands and the battles fought on them. *Stronghold Crusader* is deep, rich and rewarding.



WATCH THE PIXELS BURN: Looking down, things look pretty hot

Genre: Real time strategy ■ **Developer:** FireFly Studios ■ **Distributor:** e-xpress Interactive Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28870017
Web site: <http://stronghold.godgames.com/> ■ **Price:** Rs 699 ■ **System requirements:** 300 MHz, 64 MB RAM, 4 MB DirectX 7 compatible video Card
Rating: ★★★★★



Trainz

Like, coolz man!

Here's your chance to go one up on the government and find out firsthand, just how easy it is to muck up a rail transport system. *Trainz* attempts to bring model railroading to digital life—you can build trains from numerous engines and cars, create your own tracks and locales, and run your monsters over countries that span the globe. Alas, India is prominent by its exclusion. Models come from America, Great Britain, South Africa, Australia and Canada. You can either ride these beauties yourself or, take the passenger seat and let the AI do all the work.

An impressive amount of detailing has

gone into creating these vehicles of mass transport—the 3D models of the cars can be viewed from every angle and show satisfying detail. Real life can take a back seat as you joy-ride through mountain passes, with little likelihood of a crash. For those who demand it, the realism can be notched up, and soon-



CREATE AND RIDE: The game allows you to easily create a locale, lay your tracks and ride your favourite putt-putt through the greens

enough, the party is crashed by the burning wreckage of your creations. The graphics are a mixed-bag—while the trains are good to look at, the surroundings could have been better, and the weather should have received a better treatment. The same goes for the sound. The game, however, does not disappoint in what it offers, which is a rich and deeply involving, tinkering and building of your favourite train.

Genre: Simulation ■ **Developer:** Auran ■ **Distributor:** e-xpress Interactive Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 022-28870017 ■ **Web site:** www.auran.com/trainz/
Price: Rs 499 ■ **System requirements:** 400 MHz, 128 MB RAM, 16 MB video Card ■ **Rating:** ★★★★★

